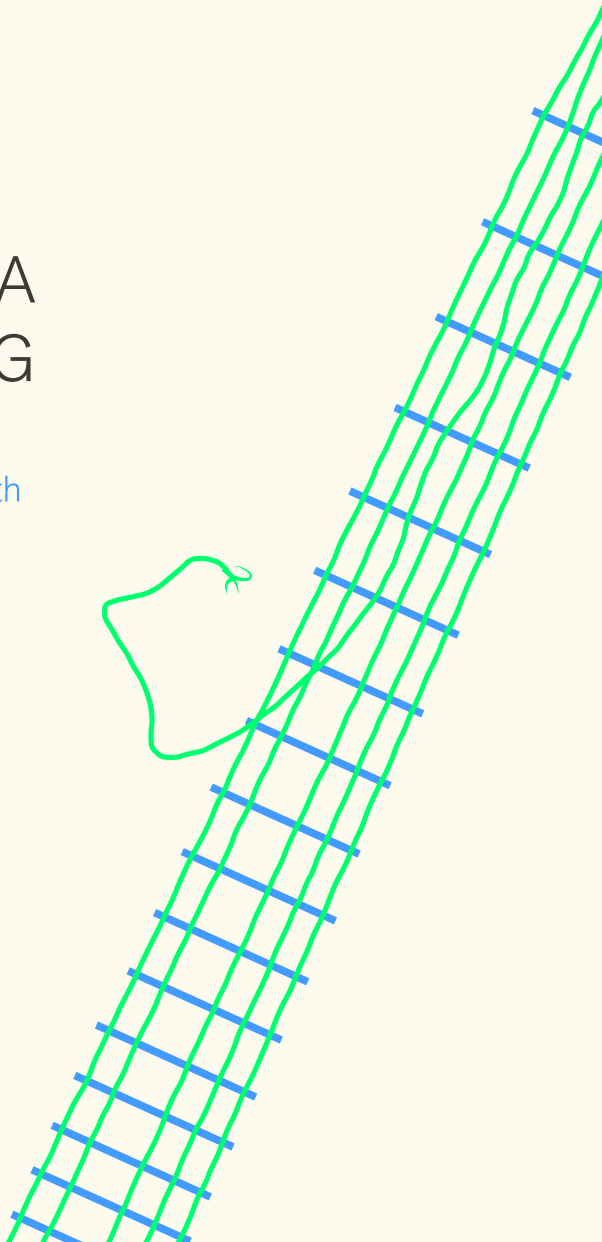




FOR A SONG

a play by
Josh Worth



For a Song

by Josh Worth

PEOPLE

Jinky

Champer

Grom 1

Grom 2

Grom 3

1.

A musician named Jinky is on stage playing a guitar. Jinky isn't necessarily a good musician (though it might help). The point is, he (or she — again — doesn't matter) is playing music.

Champer is walking by. He's feeling sad. He stops and listens to Jinky's music. Champer loves the song so much that he's moved to tears. When the song is over, he goes up to Jinky and hugs him.

CHAMPER

That was the most beautiful music I have ever heard. The way you play... It awakens something in my soul. It makes me want to thrive and be productive.

Jinky is surprised. He remembers something. He opens his guitar case. Inside are a few coins and a handwritten sign that says "Tips appreciated."

CHAMPER

Of course. Right.

Champer pats his pockets. He takes out a disappointing number of coins and drops them in the guitar case.

CHAMPER

As you may have noticed, I was looking glum when I walked by. That's because I was feeling lost and worthless. I was thinking of ending it all, if you can believe that.

Jinky gives Champer a big hug.

JINKY

Without fans like you, I wouldn't be where I am today.

CHAMPER

I admire you, playing music like that. I can't play at all. Never could. Can't sing. Can't even whistle. But I love music more than anything. It keeps me going. Keeps me productive. I sometimes think that if it weren't for music, I wouldn't even have a job.

JINKY

What is it you do?

CHAMPER

I own a guitar shop. I make guitars.

Jinky looks at his own guitar, then looks at Champer.

CHAMPER

Yes... I was noticing your piece of shit guitar.

Jinky strums a chord. A string pops out.

JINKY

It's not great.

CHAMPER

I can fix that for sure. Thing is, I'd have to charge you. I need to order a new neck, new fretboard. It's a business, you know?

Jinky nods. He's disappointed but he understands.

CHAMPER

Tell you what. You stop by my shop tomorrow. We'll work something out.

2.

Jinky enters the guitar shop. Champer is working on a guitar.

CHAMPER

There he is. The man whose music saved my life.

JINKY

Call me Jinky.

CHAMPER

Call me Champer.

Jinky is amazed by all the guitars around him. He picks one up and admires it.

JINKY

May I, Champer?

CHAMPER

Please, please. It would be my honor.

Jinky softly strums the guitar. He's delighted by the sound.

CHAMPER

You like that? Here, try this one.

Champer hands him a different guitar. Jinky strums it. He likes this one even more.

He plays a quick song. Champer is again, moved to tears.

JINKY

You sir, are a genius.

CHAMPER

You think so? I always thought so.

JINKY

This guitar feels like a part of me.
Whatever I hear in my soul just comes out
of it, as if there's nothing in between. My
fingers simply glide where they need to be.
The tone tells me when it's time to move
deeper.

CHAMPER

I really do put a lot of care into it, but
nobody seems to notice.

JINKY

Me... this guitar... Together we're a single
vibration of the universe. I would do
anything for this guitar.

CHAMPER

I mean... Do you want it?

JINKY

Of course... But it says 1,000 on the price tag.

CHAMPER

That's the price for a bad musician – someone with money but no talent. For you, I can do a discount.

JINKY

You don't understand. I am truly broke. This morning, for breakfast, I licked a banana peel. I have nothing.

CHAMPER

Nonsense. You have your music.

JINKY

You will accept music as payment for your work?

CHAMPER

Your music is priceless. I want you to take the guitar.

JINKY

That's not right. How long did it take you to make this guitar? How much did you spend on the materials?

CHAMPER

I don't even know. 200?

Jinky is worried.

JINKY

How about this? I believe you gave me a dollar for a song the other day.

CHAMPER

That's all I had.

JINKY

So if I played you 200 songs, it would add up to 200 dollars?

CHAMPER

Brilliant! You will play me two hundred songs on this guitar. After that, the guitar is yours to do with as you please.

JINKY

You have a deal.

Jinky begins to play.

CHAMPER

Oh... okay! Here we go.

Champer relaxes and listens joyfully to the song. Halfway through the song he begins looking around the space.

He finds a small chalkboard and a piece of chalk.

Jinky finishes the song.

Champer makes a mark on the chalkboard.

Jinky nods. This is going great!

He begins playing the next song.

Lights down.

3.

Lights up. There are about 10 marks on the chalkboard. Champer is doing some work.

Jinky finishes the next song and waits.

Champer looks up to notice Jinky waiting. He makes a mark on the board.

JINKY

That was two songs.

CHAMPER

It was?

JINKY

Technically speaking.

Champer makes another mark.

JINKY

They kind of flowed into one another. But I think of them as two songs.

CHAMPER

I'm sorry. I wasn't listening.

JINKY

Oh.

Jinky begins to play a sad song.

CHAMPER

No. I meant...

Champer puts a second mark on the chalkboard.

JINKY

No. That's not right. The song is for you. If you weren't listening, it shouldn't count.

CHAMPER

It's not that I wasn't listening. I was ordering some tuning pegs. I was half-listening.

JINKY

You were half-listening?

Jinky thinks.

CHAMPER

Yeah.

JINKY

But I played two songs...

Jinky thinks some more.

CHAMPER

Right...

Jinky erases one of the marks.

JINKY

You were right to begin with.

CHAMPER

No no. You played two songs whether I
listened or half-listened.

Champer puts the mark back on the chalkboard.

Quick blackout

4.

Lights up.

There are 20 marks on the board.

Jinky is lost in his music.

Champer is happily listening while working.

CHAMPER

I like this one.

Jinky stops playing.

JINKY

What's that?

CHAMPER

I just said I like this one.

JINKY

Oh... Did I play it already?

CHAMPER

Yeah. Couple times, no?

JINKY

It's a variation on a theme.

CHAMPER

Sure sure.

Jinky finishes the song. Champer is distracted.

JINKY

You can go ahead and mark that one.

Champer is preoccupied.

CHAMPER

You mind doing it?

JINKY:

Sure. No problem.

Jinky makes the mark and resumes playing.

Champer's phone rings.

CHAMPER

Hang on.

Champer answers the phone. Jinky plays softly.

CHAMPER

Hiya... No no. It's a fine time... Is that right?... Sure, I've got a couple.

Champer looks over at Jinky. Jinky stops playing.

CHAMPER

Not at all. Come on in. I'll set you right up.

Champer hangs up and looks around his shop.

JINKY:

Everything ok?

CHAMPER:

You know Grom? They play at Yummy Pie's on Mondays.

JINKY

Oh. Yes.

CHAMPER

Their guitarist's mom died.

JINKY

Oh no.

CHAMPER

No, it's great. Her family made a fortune in the funeral business. Now the guitarist has all the money and the first thing he wants is one of my guitars.

JINKY

Oh. That is great...

Pause.

JINKY

Shall I keep playing?

CHAMPER

Yes, yes. I think your music is really
turning things around.

Jinky resumes playing.

Lights down.

5.

Lights up.

About 30 marks on the board.

Jinky ends a song. Champer makes a mark.

They both look tired.

CHAMPER

You want some lunch? When's the last time you ate?

JINKY

Just the banana peel lick this morning.

CHAMPER

You like Yummy Pie's ?

JINKY

Of course.

CHAMPER

Great. I'll buy us some sandwiches if you go get 'em.

JINKY

I do like her sauerkraut sandwich.

CHAMPER

So good.

JINKY

I play there on Wednesday afternoons and Yummy Pie gives me a sauerkraut sandwich for free.

CHAMPER

Yummy Pie's great. Love her. Let me just scrounge up some money.

Champer looks around his shop for some money.

JINKY

I mean... she might let me play a couple songs and I can get us sandwiches.

CHAMPER

No no. I got some cash somewhere.

He definitely doesn't.

Jinky pauses. He's got another idea.

JINKY

How much does Yummy Pie charge for her sandwiches?

CHAMPER

Six somethin'?

JINKY

She usually gives me a lemonade which is two dollars... so eight dollars.

CHAMPER

Her lemonade's good.

Champer realizes Jinky is onto something.

JINKY

And my setlist on Wednesday has ten songs...

CHAMPER

Right.. right.

JINKY

And I get one sandwich for one of my songs...

CHAMPER

Uh huh.

JINKY

That means one of my songs is only worth 80 cents over there.

CHAMPER

You really are a genius.

JINKY

But over here my music is worth \$1 per song... and since I'm playing 200 songs and getting a \$200 guitar...

CHAMPER

I'd give it to you for free if I could...

Jinky thinks.

JINKY

Yummy Pie is going to give you two sandwiches for free!

CHAMPER

What? Why?

JINKY

Because I'm only going to play you 184 songs instead of 200.

CHAMPER

Huh... Hang on.

Champer finds a large, old adding machine and crunches some numbers.

JINKY

Math is music. Music is math.

CHAMPER

It's actually 187 songs. She only pays 80 cents a song so it's a different exchange rate. Also, one of the sandwiches is for you, so technically...

JINKY

But a second ago you were willing to buy me a sandwich for nothing.

CHAMPER

I know, but I was just saying that. I'm pretty broke myself.

JINKY

I know. But now I'm making it so you don't have to.

CHAMPER

I don't have to do any of this.

Jinky is sad.

JINKY

You're right, I'm sorry.

CHAMPER

Listen... If you go play Yummy Pie some songs and get the sandwiches, I'll knock the price for the guitar down to 185 songs.

JINKY

Ok. Alright. This is good. I play fewer songs, we both get sandwiches.

CHAMPER

You think Yummy's gonna go for it?

JINKY

Don't see why not.

Jinky exits. Quick black out.

6.

Lights up.

Jinky comes back with no sandwiches.

JINKY

She didn't go for it.

CHAMPER

Why not? It was genius!

JINKY

Something about the prices at the vegetable market and the man who sells her cabbage. They used to be lovers. The heartbreak was too much for her. She started crying while she was telling me and so I played a song to help calm her down.

CHAMPER

But no sandwich in return?

JINKY

I always play her songs to calm her down. We're friends.

CHAMPER

Not even a dollar?

JINKY

She never has money.

CHAMPER

I'm so hungry.

JINKY

Me too.

Champer thinks.

CHAMPER

Let me try.

Champer thinks some more, then grabs the guitar from Jinky's hand and exits.

Quick blackout.

7.

Lights up.

Champer comes back eating a sandwich.

CHAMPER

Sorry. She would only give me one.

Jinky watches him eat.

CHAMPER

I explained our whole arrangement and she said it made sense, but that she could only give me one sandwich.

JINKY

Where's the guitar?

CHAMPER

She had to hang onto it.

Jinky is confused.

CHAMPER

It makes total sense.

It doesn't.

CHAMPER

The guitar was collateral. You just need to go to her and play eight songs for no sandwiches, then she'll give it back to me.

Champer erases eight hash marks from the chalkboard.

JINKY

But the songs are for you. You made the guitar.

CHAMPER

Sure. And the guitar is for you. But right now, I'd rather have this sandwich.

JINKY

Well I want the sandwich more than the guitar.

CHAMPER

Go take it up with Yummy Pie. She's got both now. Guessin' she'll want sixteen songs for a sandwich.

Jinky thinks.

JINKY

But the guitar would still be yours.

CHAMPER

She's a shrewd one, that Yummy Pie.

JINKY

Was she upset?

CHAMPER

Seemed fine.

JINKY

It's because I played her that song to make her feel better about the Cabbage man.

CHAMPER

Damn Cabbage man

JINKY

He iced her out. Makes her call him Sir.

CHAMPER

Ice cold.

JINKY

But think. She wouldn't have been so shrewd with you if I hadn't calmed her down. And now here you are with a sandwich and I'm back to my shitty guitar.

CHAMPER

You could remind her about the nice song you played for her. Probably get her down to fifteen songs for a sandwich.

JINKY

That's just... Can I get a bite, at least?

CHAMPER

Sure.

Champer watches closely as Jinky takes a bite. It's very delicious.

Jinky hands the sandwich back to Champer.

Champer walks over to the chalkboard. He studies the size of the bite and erases half a hash mark.

Jinky looks at him, upset.

CHAMPER

It was 1/16th of the sandwich, was it not?

Jinky picks up his old, crappy guitar.

JINKY

Can you fix my string?

CHAMPER

I normally charge 10 for string replacement.

Jinky picks up the eraser and is about to erase ten hash marks.

CHAMPER

No. Stop. Hang on.

Champer sighs, looks around, finds another guitar and hands it to Jinky.

Jinky starts playing. Champer looks perturbed.

CHAMPER

I screwed up on this one. I can hear it now.

JINKY

It's ok. Not as good as the other but it's good.

CHAMPER

You can't hear that? It's dim and inarticulate. This backup has a cedar top instead of spruce.

Jinky shrugs.

JINKY

How much is this one?

CHAMPER

You like it better?

JINKY

It's better than my old one.

CHAMPER

It's more than 200... but if I gave you the same discount I was giving you before...

He quickly crunches some numbers on the adding machine. Jinky sneaks another bite of the sandwich.

CHAMPER

It would be 175.

JINKY

Fine. I'll take it.

CHAMPER

Less music for me, I guess.

JINKY

No no. I'll still play for you whenever you like. Whenever you walk by, I'll play your favorite song.

Jinky plays the song from the beginning.

CHAMPER

Except whenever I hear it, I'll know it could have sounded better on a better guitar. I'll be reminded of my shortcomings, and it'll take me straight back to that feeling of worthlessness.

Champer is upset.

Jinky switches abruptly to a happier song.

Champer nods and continues working.

8.

A new song fades in.

Lights up. There are about 100 hash marks on the chalkboard, some of them have been erased or redrawn. It's getting messy.

Jinky stops playing. He's exhausted.

CHAMPER

What's wrong?

JINKY

I'm still hungry and I'm worried about Grom.

CHAMPER

What for? They're rich now.

JINKY

Their music is about to get better.

CHAMPER

What? Why?

JINKY

The guitarist's mother passed away, so he'll probably have some feelings about that.

CHAMPER

Probably.

JINKY

I just know that when my bubby died, I wrote some very sad songs.

CHAMPER

Hm. Yeah.

JINKY

The one you heard when you walked past was written for my bubby.

CHAMPER

Sorry about your bubby.

JINKY

He was a good fish.

Pause.

CHAMPER

How's your mother doing?

Pause.

JINKY

I never knew her.

CHAMPER

Oh – that's way worse. You'll be fine.

Jinky resumes playing, then stops abruptly.

JINKY

I wonder how many sandwiches Grom gets for their set at Yummy Pie's.

CHAMPER

Yeah. Dunno. There's three of them.

JINKY

If they each get a sandwich... Does that mean their songs are worth three times as much as mine?

CHAMPER

They're not that great.

JINKY

They act like they are.

CHAMPER

That's their act. They got swagger.

Jinky resumes playing and attempts an awkward dance move.

He stops.

JINKY

I'm so hungry.

CHAMPER

Me too. Grom was supposed to be here already.

JINKY

How much are you going to charge them?

CHAMPER

What do you think? Two thousand? If I can get two thousand, I'll buy us both dinner.

JINKY

You'd do that?

CHAMPER

Of course.

JINKY

You're all right.

Grom enters. There are three of them. They move together harmoniously.

CHAMPER

Greetings. You must be Grom.

GROM 1

I am Grom.

GROM 2

I am here for my guitar.

GROM 3

I play drums.

GROM 1

Together, we are Grom.

GROM 2

I've always wanted one of your guitars.

CHAMPER

Great. I've been working all day on it. Got it all tuned up.

He hands the guitar to Grom 2, but Grom 1 grabs it, inspects it, and passes it to Grom 2.

Grom 2 strums the guitar and plays an aggressive riff, causing all of Grom to immediately snap into a choreographed swagger dance.

The swagger dance lasts for three seconds. When Grom 2 stops playing, Grom snaps out of the dance.

Jinky also plays a chord.

GROM 1

(to Champer)

Who is he?

CHAMPER

You don't know Jinky?

JINKY
I play at Yummy Pie's on Wednesdays.

Grom 1 shrugs.

GROM 1
We play there Mondays.

CHAMPER
Jinky likes my guitars, don't you Jinky?

Jinky catches on.

JINKY
Absolutely. There is no finer craftsman.

GROM 1
Grom has come for the guitar. What is the price?

CHAMPER
Two thousand five hundred for this one.

JINKY
Worth every penny.

GROM 1
Do you have others?

Grom 2 strums the guitar loudly and shakes his head.

Grom 1 stares at him. They have a silent stare down.

CHAMPER

I could go down to two thousand.

GROM 1

We will buy this guitar.

CHAMPER

Wonderful.

What follows is a rapid, choreographed transaction.

Champer crunches numbers on the adding machine

Grom 1 gestures to Grom 3.

Grom 3 steps forward. Reaches into his bag, pulls out a stack of bills, removes a few bills from the stack, and steps forward.

Grom 2 inspects the stack and nods.

Grom 1 inspects the stack and nods.

Grom 3 hands the stack to Champer.

Champer rings a bell, makes a mark on a receipt and hands it to Grom 3.

Grom 1 pushes Grom 3 aside, takes the receipt, inspects it, and hands it back to Grom 3.

CHAMPER

A pleasure doing business with you.

Champer tries to get Grom out the door.

Grom 1 and 3 begin to exit. Grom 2 is entranced by the guitar. He's almost in tears.

GROM 2

This is going to change everything.

Champer is touched. He and Grom 2 share a moment.

JINKY

Will you still be playing at Yummy Pie's?

GROM 1

Every Monday.

GROM 3

We each get a sandwich and a lemonade.

JINKY

Sure, me too. But for how many songs?

GROM 1

Thirty two songs.

GROM 3

We play fast. We play all night.

Jinky runs the numbers in his head.

GROM 3

Our songs bring in the customers.

GROM 1

We feed off the crowd.

JINKY

My songs are worth more. You're getting seventy-five cents a song. I get eighty.

GROM 3

You're a sell-out.

GROM 1

You're all about the pennies. We're about the river of rhythms coursing through the night.

CHAMPER

That's great.

JINKY

Champer here says two hundred of my songs are worth the price of a guitar.

CHAMPER

Come on now.

GROM 1

You're giving guitars away for songs?

CHAMPER

It was a special deal. He's broke.

GROM 1

We just gave you money and we could
have given you songs?

CHAMPER

You would have had to play an awful lot of
songs.

GROM 1

He's only playing two hundred.

JINKY

He likes my songs better.

CHAMPER

No no. Everyone's songs are great.

GROM 3

Our songs transcend.

CHAMPER

Right. You can't put a price on them.

JINKY

But you can put a price on mine?

CHAMPER

You put a price on it. I wanted to give you
the guitar for nothing.

GROM 1

You're giving away free guitars?

CHAMPER

He's a friend.

JINKY

I am?

CHAMPER

Right?

GROM 1

And we are not friends?

CHAMPER

Like I said. It was a pleasure doing
business with you.

Grom is angry. It's a tense standoff.

Jinky plays an angry chord.

*Grom 2 plays a chord. All of Grom does a momentary
swagger dance.*

Jinky plays a gentle chord.

JINKY

Sorry to hear about your Mother.

Grom 2 plays another chord.

GROM 2
My mother was a whore.

Pause.

GROM 3
Not technically.

GROM 1
Not like Melody.

GROM 3
Melody is my girlfriend.

GROM 1
She's an actual whore.

GROM 3
Sex worker.

GROM 2
My mother was much worse.

GROM 3
Melody's an excellent sex worker.

GROM 1
She does excellent sex work.

GROM 2
Very professional.

GROM 1

Our inspiration.

GROM 2

My mother betrayed my father. My father worked his fingers to the bone running the funeral parlor, embalming the dead, making them presentable, dealing with their bruises and fluids.

CHAMPER

Yes. I believe he dealt with my Uncle's fluids. Excellent work. Very professional.

GROM 2

Until he died himself. And no one was there to make him presentable.

CHAMPER

Where was your mother?

GROM 2

Off with the man who sells cabbage at the market.

JINKY

The Cabbage Man?

GROM 2

And now she's dead.

GROM 1

What do you know of the Cabbage Man?

JINKY

He broke the heart of Yummy Pie.

GROM 2

He broke my mother's heart.

CHAMPER

Goddamn Cabbage Man.

GROM 2

She died of heartbreak.

GROM 1

No one breaks the heart of Yummy Pie.

JINKY

We need her.

GROM 2

More than Melody.

GROM 3

The same maybe.

JINKY

The Cabbage Man gave her a discount on cabbage until he broke things off. Now he charges her extra and makes her call him Sir.

GROM 1

They once were lovers but now she must
call him Sir.

CHAMPER

Her sauerkraut sandwiches cost more to
make.

GROM 2

He made me call him Sir... after my
father died, my mother thought it was
time for him to meet me. He sat in my
living room and pretended to be interested
in my music. He said "Your mother says
you like music. You should play a song for
me." And so I did. Because he seemed to
make my mother happy. And he said,
"That was very good." And I said, "Thank
you, dude." and he said, "Not *dude*. 'SIR.
Thank you, SIR.'" And I just shrugged...
But he said, "Say it. 'thank you SIR.'" And
I said it. And my mother just sat there.

CHAMPER

I think I see what kind of man this
Cabbage Man is.

GROM 3

You should write a song about that.

JINKY

Nah.

GROM 2

I'm tired of songs. What can a song do but
bring more heartbreak?

CHAMPER

I like songs.

JINKY

He's done with songs. He's got money
now.

Grom 2 plays an aggressive chord.

GROM 2

I don't need the money.

CHAMPER

Who needs money?

GROM 2

I need that man to pay.

CHAMPER

I dunno.

JINKY

He's behind all the heartbreak and
sadness.

GROM 1

He should pay.

JINKY

We're just trying to make things beautiful
and what is he doing? Stealing the wife of
the man who deals with the dead?

GROM 3

Give us the head of the Cabbage Man!

JINKY

Breaking the heart of the woman who
feeds us?

GROM 3

Give us the head of the Cabbage Man!

CHAMPER

Raising the price of cabbage so we can't
buy a sandwich?

EVERYONE

Off with the head of the Cabbage Man!

*Jinky lifts his guitar above his head, upside-down like
an axe.*

Grom 1 sees a saw lying around and raises it high.

Grom 3 wields a mop.

Grom 2 strikes a power chord.

The angry mob storms off-stage in unison.

Lights down.

9.

Jinky enters.

JINKY

It was so easy!

Champer enters behind him.

CHAMPER

The people in the market were so happy!

Grom 2 enters, playing an obnoxious song of victory.

JINKY

Why have we struggled so long?

CHAMPER

I thought they might arrest us, but they
cheered us on instead!

Grom 3 enters. The mop he was holding is soaked in blood.

*Grom 1 enters, holding the head of the Cabbage Man.
It is a head of cabbage.*

GROM 1

(Speaking to the Cabbage head)

We will bring you to Yummy Pie and let
her make sandwiches out of you.

CHAMPER
Sauerkraut sandwiches for all!

GROM 3
I'm hungry now!

JINKY
So hungry.

Grom 1 tosses the head of cabbage in the air.

Grom 3 catches it and takes a messy bite.

He passes it to Grom 2 who takes a bite, passes it to Grom 1 and resumes his victorious song.

It's clear that Grom is hogging the spoils, so Champer snatches the cabbage head and takes a bite.

Jinky tries forcing his way into the frenzy but is unsuccessful.

JINKY
I'm so hungry!

Champer hears him and tosses him a chunk of cabbage.

Grom 2 continues his song, but can't eat and play at the same time so he drops his guitar to eat.

Jinky begins to play. As he watches the others consume the bits of cabbage, the revelry subsides and the song becomes a dirge of empathy and heartbreak.

He puts the guitar down and gathers up some scraps of cabbage of his own.

Everyone skulks away from each other, nibbling their own portion.

Lights down.

